TSA 2023

Critical Thinking

Questions taken from the TSA Oxford 2023 Section 1 question paper

Questions	Total marks	Time limit
25	25	45 minutes

Instructions

- You have **45 minutes** to answer all **25 questions**.
- Each question is worth **one mark**. There are no penalties for incorrect answers, so attempt every question.
- Each question has five options, A to E. Choose the one option you consider correct.
- Calculators are **not** permitted. You may use this paper for rough working.
- Questions are numbered 1 to 25 for this set. The number in brackets shows the question's number in the original TSA 2023 paper, e.g. **1 (Q3)**.

How the time limit was set

The time limit follows the TARA Critical Thinking module (22 questions in 40 minutes), scaled to the 25 questions in this set: 25 × 40 ÷ 22 = 45.45 minutes, rounded to the nearest minute (45 minutes).

Score: _____ / 25

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1 (Q1) It may seem like we're living in the age of the conspiracy theory, but 'alternative facts' have been around since long before conspiracy theorists claimed the 1969 moon landing was faked by a movie production crew. The truth is that society could be much smarter in how it addresses the popularity of such theories. While it may sound counter-intuitive, it's actually not all that useful to directly challenge someone's belief in a conspiracy theory. That sort of intervention just tends to reinforce existing beliefs. More effective strategies focus on how information is delivered by scientists and other authorities and on developing open communication between the public and those providing 'official' or 'expert' information. Finally, it's critical not to simply dismiss conspiracy theories as trivial nonsense, as they can reveal much about levels of trust, equality, and other key components of a functioning society.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Society could be much smarter in how it addresses the popularity of conspiracy theories.

B It's not all that useful to directly challenge someone's belief in a conspiracy theory.

C Challenging someone's belief in a conspiracy theory just tends to reinforce it.

D Better strategies for dealing with conspiracy theories focus on authorities' information delivery and communication with the public.

E It's critical not to simply dismiss conspiracy theories as trivial nonsense.

2 (Q3) Religious believers often try to convince others to act morally by offering the reward of some kind of 'heaven'. But this approach misunderstands the nature of morality. We should do the right thing because it is the right thing, not because of selfish desires about the consequences. Ethics is a matter of virtuous character, not seeking rewards and avoiding punishments. For instance, if you believe it is right to pray daily then you should do so even if it will not get you into heaven.

Which one of the following best illustrates the principle used in the above argument?

A You should not jump queues even if you are in a rush to get somewhere.

B You should be honest about your friend's new outfit even if you might offend them.

C You should not steal from an organisation even if you believe that it is corrupt.

D You should not give to charity just to avoid feeling guilty.

E You should return lost property even if the owner is not offering any compensation.

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3 (Q4) When we are walking our centre of mass is constantly moving up and down. If we are wearing a backpack then this also moves up and down as we walk. A new prototype has been developed in which the backpack is suspended on sliding rails that allow it to move more smoothly. It is attached to a pair of rubber ropes on a pulley system which acts like a car's suspension to reduce the impact of the pack as you walk, making it easier to carry. Additionally, the relative movement between the pack and the body is used to power a small generator that converts the mechanical power into electricity. Although these features will increase the price of the product, this backpack is likely to become one of the most popular on the market.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the above argument?

A Cars that have better suspension systems tend to be more popular than other models.

B People carrying this new type of backpack will be able to use the electricity as it is generated.

C The most important feature of a backpack is the ease with which it can be carried.

D Current devices that can generate electricity as you walk do not create as much electricity as the new backpack will.

E Consumers will consider the benefits of the new backpack design to be worth the increase in price.

4 (Q5) Unfortunately, in recent years, teachers in the UK have 'gone soft' and no longer have the right priorities. Most schools these days are concerned with children's happiness, confidence and self-expression rather than maximising academic achievement. We should reverse this trend and re-introduce more traditional teaching methods (such as those focused on memorisation) in all schools. After all, the purpose of teaching is to develop children's learning, and discipline and good exam results can get you into a top university and ensure a high-paying career later in life. Traditional methods are tried-and-tested, so they are the best way of ensuring good academic outcomes for children.

Which one of the following, if true, most weakens the above argument?

A Some private schools have maintained a focus on traditional teaching methods despite changes in attitudes among education professionals.

B Traditional teaching methods involve the use of strict punishment in schools to improve discipline, which some parents dislike.

C Modern technology has increased the range of teaching methods available.

D Careers have changed significantly over time and now require a wider range of skills than those represented by academic achievement.

E As part of a pilot programme, some schools have started allowing students to opt out of homework in order to provide a better 'work–life balance'.

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5 (Q9) Researchers believe that shortened sleep, and shortened rapid eye movement (REM) sleep in particular, contributes to a shorter lifespan. For every 5% reduction in REM sleep, mortality rates increase by 13% to 17% among older and middle-aged adults, they report. But is there really a connection? A study comparing the sleeping patterns of men and women from 28 different countries using fitness trackers has shown that Japan is the country that sleeps the least. Japanese men and women sleep only an average of 6 hours and 30 minutes, and 6 hours and 40 minutes, respectively. Yet Japanese women have a life expectancy of 87.3 years – the second highest in the world after Hong Kong – while male life expectancy in Japan is the third highest internationally. What this shows is that shortened sleep does not, in fact, contribute to a shorter lifespan.

Which one of the following best illustrates the flaw in the above argument?

A Health problems that shorten people's lifespans might also interfere with their sleep in old age.

B The proportion of sleep that is REM sleep might decrease with age.

C The length of time that the Japanese sleep might be gradually increasing.

D Japanese life expectancy might now be falling to a level closer to the global average.

E The life expectancy of Japanese people might be even longer if they slept for longer.

6 (Q10) Every participant in the cross-country race received either a trophy for finishing in the top ten, or a medal for participating. Amy finished in twelfth place, which means she will have been awarded a medal for participating.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A The school can take in one hundred more pupils next year if they build more classrooms. They have not received approval for the building work, so they will not be able to increase their pupil intake.

B The shopkeeper can keep her store open on the weekends if she hires people who can work weekend shifts. It is Sunday and the store is open, so she must have hired new employees.

C Whenever Cara and her family visit the zoo they have an ice cream at the outdoor café or – if it's raining – visit the butterfly house. It wasn't raining when they went yesterday, so they must have had an ice cream at the café.

D If fireworks continue to be sold illegally, hospitals can expect a spike in fire-related injuries during the holiday season. There was a decrease in hospital admissions due to such injuries this year, so the efforts to crack down on illegal fireworks must be succeeding.

E There is only enough space left in the moving van for an armchair or a side table. The armchair has some sentimental value to Peter, so the side table will be left behind.

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7 (Q11) It is widely claimed that ancient stone circles were designed as astronomical observatories – that the stones were laid out to create sightlines to various celestial objects. While it seems clear that solar and lunar alignments were important in the layout of many circles, there are problems when it comes to the stars. Many stones are missing or have toppled over and it is extremely difficult to fix their original position. Further, the position of the stars in relation to each other is constantly changing. Using the laws of physics, we can recreate a map of the heavens for any period in the past. But to draw conclusions about the orientation of any sightline, we have to know exactly when the stones were erected. Unfortunately, none of the dating methods used, including radiocarbon dating, is accurate enough for that. Finally, there are hundreds of combinations of stones at any site that produce sightlines.

Which one of the following can be drawn as a conclusion from the above passage?

A The builders of the stone circles knew less about the stars than modern humans.

B Better dating methods would let us determine the importance of sightlines.

C Ancient astronomical observations made using stone circles were inaccurate.

D It is unclear whether the stars were important in the layout of stone circles.

E The sun and moon were more important to ancient humans than the stars.

8 (Q15) A cataract is a clouding of the lens inside the eye, which results in decreased vision and eventually blindness. Approximately half of all cases of blindness globally are cataract-related. Cataracts often lead to social exclusion, unemployment, depression and lower life expectancy. Treatment by surgical replacement of the affected lens offers great value for the immense benefits it brings not only to the individual but also to society as a whole. Cataract surgery is usually quite quick, does not require large, big-budget equipment or an overnight stay in hospital, and has a more than 90 per cent success rate. This medical intervention is relatively inexpensive and straightforward if the necessary infrastructure and expertise are in place.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A Approximately half of all cases of blindness globally are cataract-related.

B Cataracts often lead to social exclusion, unemployment, depression and lower life expectancy.

C Surgical cataract treatment offers great value for the immense benefits it brings not only to the individual but also to society as a whole.

D Cataract surgery is usually quite quick, does not require large, big-budget equipment or an overnight stay in hospital, and has a more than 90 per cent success rate.

E Cataract surgery is relatively inexpensive and straightforward if the necessary infrastructure and expertise are in place.

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9 (Q16) Stora Karlsö is a Swedish island that is now set aside for wildlife conservation and is uninhabited by people except for the presence of 'day-trippers', who visit for only a few hours at a time. The population of murre seabirds there declined in the past because of people hunting them and collecting their eggs, but started to recover once these activities were banned. During one recent summer, Stora Karlsö was closed to the tourists, and scientists monitoring the island made a surprising discovery. The percentage of eggs hatched by the murres dropped by 26% as dozens more white-tailed eagles flocked to the island. It turns out that the eagles were encouraged by the lack of human visitors, while the murres were scared away from their nests by the influx of the larger birds.

Which one of the following can be drawn as a conclusion from the above passage?

A Focusing the efforts of a nature reserve on one particular species is not always an effective conservation strategy.

B The presence of people has a beneficial effect on wildlife species' populations in some cases.

C Some kinds of bird species are less of a conservation priority than others.

D Limiting certain kinds of human activity is the fastest approach to increasing the population of a wildlife species.

E It is not always possible to conserve every species in some kinds of ecosystems.

10 (Q17) Calling a colleague 'immature' is not unlawful if they are behaving in a genuinely childish manner, a tribunal has ruled. In a recent case an employee sued the director of the company where he worked for age discrimination. However, the director successfully argued that her calling the employee 'immature' was prompted by his abrasive manner and inability to lead a team, rather than his relatively young age. The tribunal dismissed the claims of discrimination, so directors of companies should not be overly concerned about the legality of accusing their employees of being immature.

Which one of the following best illustrates the flaw in the above argument?

A An abrasive manner and inability to lead a team may be an indicator of immaturity.

B The fact that a tribunal has dismissed a case does not mean that the company in question acted ethically.

C The tribunal may have examined the character of the director rather than what had actually happened.

D Whether or not something is lawful may not be the only concern that directors might have.

E The fact that one case has been dismissed does not mean that all future cases will be dismissed.

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11 (Q21) In recent years, the production and visibility of colourised and 'restored' historical photographs has grown exponentially, owing to both social media and the introduction of user-friendly colourisation software. But the expansion of the technical capacity and popular appetite to alter historical photography has not been matched by sufficient debate about the assumptions and consequences of this practice. Colourisers do not address photographs as physical artefacts with unique histories of creation and reception: they treat original photos as 'windows' onto the past that can be 'improved' for viewers. But a photograph is never just a neutral representation of the past. Every photograph carries with it a complicated history of who took it, who looked at it, how it was shaped by the technology behind it, and what all this means for questions of representation, experience, and history. Colourisation blocks out this rich repository of historical meaning, substituting a fleeting jolt of novelty for deeper understanding of the image.

Which one of the following, if true, most strengthens the above argument?

A Artificial intelligence is now being used to colourise photographs automatically.

B Colourisation techniques are almost as old as photography itself.

C Some photographers of the past chose to use black and white film instead of colour.

D Some universities no longer teach courses on the history of photography.

E Colourisers rarely have academic experience of studying history.

12 (Q22) There has been discontent amongst students following the decision of a number of UK universities to use automated marking software to assess students' written work. Of course, there are ethical issues surrounding the use of such software. But a simple reason why the students are right to feel aggrieved is that it is not clear that they were told, when embarking on the course, that this would happen. You have every right to complain about something which affects you if you have not previously been informed, consulted, or given your consent. The students are therefore justified in their complaints.

Which one of the following illustrates the principle used in the above argument?

A A customer has every right to demand a refund rather than accept an alternative product offered by a supplier.

B Someone selling their house ought to inform the buyer if they cannot guarantee the property will be left satisfactorily clean.

C A patient who has been prescribed a medication that has unpleasant side effects is entitled to complain if they were not warned of this possibility.

D A consumer who is offered a no-returns purchase ought to be fully informed about the implications of this transaction.

E A citizen who is arrested for a suspected crime has every right to complain if they believe the police used unnecessary force.

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13 (Q23) The chef will not go ahead with her cooking class tomorrow unless at least fifteen people sign up for it by 5 pm today. It is now 4 pm and twenty people have already registered, so she will be teaching the class tomorrow.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A Unless enough rain fell during the summer months to water the crops, they would all have died out by July. It is now August and the crops are still surviving, so there was adequate rainfall earlier in the year.

B The architect's plan cannot be approved by the local authorities unless it meets all of the relevant regulations. The plan will be rejected since the architect has disregarded two of the rules.

C Unless more public transport options are made available, traffic congestion in town will never improve. The mayor has announced that new bus lines will be introduced next month, so traffic will start to ease up after that.

D The competition is not conducted fairly unless all of the judges are completely impartial. One of the judges is biased in favour of one of the competitors because they are from the same country, so that competitor is more likely to win.

E Unless the data has been analysed accurately, it cannot be included in the final report. The report was handed in today and did not contain the data, so mistakes must have been made with its analysis.

14 (Q27) When hiring new employees for senior positions, many companies focus their search on applicants who already have some previous experience working in a similar job. This happens even though simply having had another job does not automatically mean that that person performed well in that role. Moreover, some people got their jobs because they have personal connections with the employers, not because they were the most competent or suitable candidate. And even if an applicant is highly qualified and did excel at another job, the different work environments at different organisations often make it challenging for them to apply their previous work experience to a new role. This shows that companies that automatically reject inexperienced applicants are taking the wrong approach.

Which one of the following best illustrates the flaw in the above argument?

A Companies may be trying to save time by focusing on candidates who have previous work experience.

B It may be that good performance, although not guaranteed by previous experience, is impossible without it.

C Just because someone got a job through personal connections does not mean that they are unqualified for it.

D Inexperienced applicants may be able to access internships and other training opportunities.

E Just because companies focus on applicants with previous work experience does not mean they do not consider other qualifications.

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15 (Q28) According to legend, the ancient cities of both Thebes and Troy were founded, not at the summit of a hill, nor the junction of two waterways, but where a cow decided to lie down. The practice of allowing cows to choose where a city should be built would seem to be arbitrary and bizarre; a little reflection tells us that it is perhaps not so strange after all. Since a city means a sizeable population, there must be plentiful sources of meat, milk, leather and cheese, not to mention strong draught animals for ploughing fields and pulling carts. If a cow is taken enough by the amenities of a place to feel able to lie down, then it is worth paying attention.

Which one of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the above argument?

A According to legend, both Thebes and Troy were founded where a cow chose to lie down.

B The practice of allowing cows to choose where a city should be built would seem to be arbitrary and bizarre.

C A little reflection tells us that it is not so strange to allow a cow to choose where to build a city.

D Cities demand plentiful sources of meat, milk, leather, cheese, as well as strong draught animals.

E If a cow is taken enough by the amenities of a place to feel able to lie down, then it is worth paying attention.

16 (Q29) Why is it that disagreements have a tendency to become so heated? The problem arises from the fact that people who think differently from you, on any topic, are perceived subconsciously as a threat. Not a physical threat, necessarily, but a threat to your reputation. Why is this? Because if someone who thinks differently from you is right (or merely perceived by others to be right), it typically implies that you are wrong. And being wrong (or seen to be wrong) is something that we all fear. Our worry is that it will damage our credibility as someone others should listen to or trust. And trust, naturally, is an extremely valuable commodity for social creatures such as ourselves.

Which one of the following can be drawn as a conclusion from the above passage?

A If two people think differently, they cannot both be right.

B In order to be effective in a debate, someone must earn the trust of those around them.

C We fear reputational threats just as much as we do physical threats.

D If someone thinks the same way as you, they will not perceive you as a threat.

E If we did not fear being wrong, disagreements would be less likely to get heated.

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17 (Q33) Over the past few decades, many companies have developed sustainability initiatives designed to improve their environmental performance across areas ranging from water usage to the recyclability of products. At the same time, there has been an increase in award programmes designed to recognise achievement in such initiatives. Unsurprisingly, these awards attract criticism and scepticism, especially since it is often the companies that nominate themselves to receive them. While some of the awards may not represent meaningful progress, we shouldn't dismiss or reject them entirely. Many are awarded by judging panels that include representatives from environmental organisations. Moreover, the positive publicity and other benefits that come with winning awards help gain support for a company's sustainability efforts amongst the senior decision-makers at that company.

Which one of the following, if true, most strengthens the above argument?

A Participation in award programmes can be an enjoyable experience for company employees.

B The award programmes provide a way for companies to learn about environmental management advancements within their own industries.

C Members of the public lack the knowledge needed to assess claims about sustainability-related achievements.

D Companies that have been previous award winners go on to participate on judging panels for the award programmes.

E The awards help companies that win them reduce the amount of money they spend on advertising their products.

18 (Q34) A common method of punishing minor offences such as speeding or dropping litter is to impose monetary fines on the offender. These fines also aim to deter people from breaking the law in the first place. However, it is evident that fines are an unfair method of deterring and punishing people. If caught, wealthy people will be able to pay off fines with little to no trouble, and are therefore unlikely to feel deterred by the punishment. On the other hand, poorer people are more likely to have to borrow money to pay the fine, or even face further punishment such as jail time for not paying the original fine, which are disproportionately negative outcomes for committing a minor offence.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the above argument?

A There are other methods of punishment that are fairer than imposing fines.

B People are aware of the punishments they will face if they are caught breaking the law.

C Poorer people are more likely to get caught committing minor offences than wealthier people.

D An offender's wealth does not affect the amount they are fined.

E People are unlikely to repeat an offence if they are punished for it the first time.

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19 (Q35) So far, most attention given to reproductive health has focused on women's fertility. Therefore, it's a welcome development that researchers are showing more concern about what impacts the fertility of men. Factors already known to affect sperm production range from the ageing process to poor diets and fitness levels. Now, increasing attention is being paid to workplace chemical exposure as another potential factor. For example, some studies have found that the longer men work in certain factory jobs, the lower the quality of their sperm production. This finding is enough to identify factory chemical exposure as a priority risk and begin changing factory working conditions to reduce it.

Which one of the following best illustrates the flaw in the above argument?

A Fertility problems may be more common amongst women than they are amongst men.

B Just because there are risks associated with workplace chemical exposure does not mean other risks to men's fertility should be ignored.

C Lower quality sperm production may already be an issue by the time men start factory jobs.

D Just because lower quality sperm production is associated with more time in a job doesn't mean it is caused by that job.

E Just because one risk to fertility is reduced doesn't mean that someone's reproductive health will actually be improved.

20 (Q39) For an earthquake to take place, there needs to be pressure generated between the Earth's tectonic plates. The pressure has increased along this fault line, so we can expect an earthquake soon.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A An increase in wages implies an increase in a company's running costs. As wages have been frozen for a year, we can assume that it costs the same now to run the company as it did 12 months ago.

B To survive, coral reefs need clear water that lets sunlight through. This reef is thriving, so the water conditions must be ideal for it.

C If a cat is to live with humans successfully when it is fully grown, it must be socialised with them while still a kitten. This cat grew up in the wild, so it is unlikely to make a good pet.

D A sonic boom implies that an object has broken the sound barrier. The jet did not break the sound barrier, so cannot have created a sonic boom.

E A ship cannot be steered without a rudder. This vessel is equipped with one, so we should be able to change course.

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21 (Q40) A political party in Freedonia has raised overblown concerns about freedom of speech, claiming that hate-speech laws are a form of censorship and undermine academic freedom. After all, these laws may prevent people from voicing their opinions in public, and academics may not be able to teach and write without interference. However, the party has no leg to stand on in decrying these hate-speech laws: they proposed a law that would ban Freedonian teachers from teaching negative perspectives on the history of the Freedonian empire. This hypocrisy is very disappointing: as the old saying goes, people in glass houses shouldn't throw stones.

Which one of the following best illustrates the principle used in the above argument?

A Those who have only negative things to say should say nothing at all.

B Those who cheat in their university exams should automatically fail their degree.

C Those who are rude to their friends should not complain if their friends are rude in return.

D Teachers should be careful what they teach pupils, in case they upset their parents.

E Historical figures who did awful things should be scrutinised and criticised in public debate.

22 (Q41) Most countries around the world only allow citizens to vote in elections when they are at least 18 years old. Many oppose lowering this to 16, pointing out that at this age, people cannot even legally drive a car in most places. However, voting is not like driving a car – it does not require impulse control or split-second decision-making, abilities which are not well developed during the teenage years. Voters are not presented with the candidates just seconds before they must make a choice. Rather, voters have time to deliberate and think about their decision, and this type of dispassionate reasoning matures, on average, in the mid-teens. This is the key factor that should determine who is allowed to vote. Moreover, many adults much older than 16 are not more knowledgeable about politics than your average 16-year-old, nor do they even deliberate all that much before casting their votes.

Which one of the following can be drawn as a conclusion from the above passage?

A The minimum age at which someone can legally vote should be the same as the minimum age for legal driving.

B The minimum ages to vote and to drive should be based on individual ability, not on age alone.

C Lowering the minimum age to vote to 16 would increase the number of people turning up to vote in elections.

D The minimum age to vote is influenced by the minimum age at which one can drive.

E The average 16-year-old is just as qualified to vote in an election as many older adults.

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23 (Q45) Online courses are becoming more common in colleges and universities, which is a worrying trend given the data that we have on how effective they are. Studies have found that students taking online courses are much more likely to multitask during their lessons compared to students in traditional in-person classes. After all, with no teacher present in the room to deter you from checking your emails, listening to music, and scrolling through social media, it is much easier to be tempted by these distractions. This is a problem because we also have plenty of data to show that multitasking during educational activities significantly reduces how much you learn. Indeed, students taking online courses, on average, end up performing worse in assessments and are more likely to drop out than students taking in-person courses. Clearly, online courses are detrimental to learning compared to in-person ones.

Which one of the following, if true, most weakens the above argument?

A Online courses tend to attract students who are also working part time or have childcare responsibilities.

B Highly focused students attending online courses still perform well in assessments.

C Some students can only attend online courses because they have difficulty moving around.

D There are also distractions during in-person classes, such as the presence of classmates.

E Older students tend to be more motivated than younger students.

24 (Q47) In the USA, interest paid on a home loan is tax-deductible (meaning it can be deducted from your taxable income, reducing the tax you pay to the government). This tax break is known as mortgage interest deduction, and it should be abolished. After all, the poorest Americans generally rent their homes rather than owning them, and rent cannot be deducted from taxes. And certain technicalities related to how taxes are filed often prevent poorer homeowners from receiving the deduction. This means that the poorest Americans benefit the least from mortgage interest deduction. The people who benefit the most are the richest, since they own the most expensive houses and have the largest tax bills, and often employ accountants to file their taxes for maximum deductions. The American government could more than double rental assistance payments to poorer Americans with the money lost as a result of this tax break.

Which one of the following is an underlying assumption of the above argument?

A Government money should not be spent subsidising private household consumption choices.

B The financial benefits you receive from the government should not depend on whether you are rich or poor.

C Money raised by taxing the rich should be used to support the poor.

D There are no low-cost accounting services that poorer Americans can access.

E The government should not offer tax breaks that benefit the richest most and the poorest least.

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25 (Q49) To win business investment, you need a good product and a well-developed business plan. Your product is brilliant, but you haven't spent enough time on the plan. So it's unlikely you'll get funding.

Which one of the following most closely parallels the reasoning used in the above argument?

A For the school to approve their proposal for meat-free lunches, the students must develop a menu and win support from their peers. The student body has approved their new menu in a poll, so it's unlikely the school will continue to serve meat.

B The only way their team will be disqualified is if they miss a match and fail to notify the tournament director at least three hours before the start of play. They couldn't attend the first match but told the director in plenty of time, meaning they won't be disqualified.

C The new hotel manager must be fluent in Mandarin and Korean. This candidate speaks both, meaning the hotel won't need to interview anyone else.

D To earn a distinction in music, you must perform in public concerts or write your own music composition. You don't have time for the concerts or the composition, so it's unlikely you'll earn a distinction.

E If they want to take a holiday that is affordable and unique, the friends can volunteer on a farm or at a nature reserve. The farm only hosts volunteers for the weekend, so they probably won't go there.

END OF TEST

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